

If young people learn to exercise their vote, they will also begin to care for their community. **A BILLION VOICES** is a billion votes.

The ongoing presidential election in America is an extraordinary run on many counts, charged with emotions of race and gender. "Change is coming", both candidates promise, and the most visible change is the record participation of the youth, thanks in large measure to the Obama phenomenon. The youth turnout in the US almost doubled to 17 per cent this election in comparison to the 9 per cent in the 2000 elections. Over 6.5 million young people, under the age of 30, participated in the 2008 primaries and caucuses. In a nutshell, the youth there have been politically inspired and reversed a declining trend of youth voting.

Compare this to the youth's involvement in Indian politics. The 2004 Lok Sabha elections had a total turnout of 56 per cent. The break-up between rural and urban voter turnout is around 60 to 40 per cent. In the absence of reliable youth data on voting, I have used small sampling studies and extrapolated to arrive at our young urban voter turnout—between the ages of 18 and 30—in the 2004 elections. The number works out to approximately six million, which doesn't seem so bad, until we look at it as a percentage—a mere 9 per cent of the urban youth eligible to vote. This political abstinence by our youth, in a country with 47 per cent of our population under the age of 20, does not bode well for the future health of our young democracy. We are in danger of creating a permanent and large constituency of non-voters.

Engaging in the politics of our city, state and country, is engaging in nation building. Yet most Indians, young and old, prefer to

stay away from politics, viewing it as a vehicle of corrupt power and crime. Engaging with government is anathema to most Indians. Faced with a choice, we prefer to go over, under and around government, anything rather than engage with it. While we do volunteer for causes, the average Indian feels that he or she has little political or social impact beyond the occasional power trip to the ballot box.

Looking towards the US again, volunteering is considered a bedrock of community building, inculcated through schools and colleges. In his campaign speech, Barack Obama promises a \$4,000 tuition credit for students who commit time to community service. More than 60 million average Americans commit volunteer time. Youth volunteering in the US is estimated to be 36 per cent between the ages of 15 and 25 and more than half of those volunteering firmly believe that they can make some difference to the community they live in. The youth that volunteer in political organisations—13 per cent—believe they can make a difference on various social or political issues. Studies in the US indicate that youth are twice as likely to volunteer, engage in politics or vote, when they grow up in a household where someone volunteers.

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THE NUMBER OF AMERICANS WHO COMMIT TIME TO COMMUNITY SERVICE. 36 PER CENT OF US YOUTH BETWEEN THE AGES OF 15 AND 25 DO VOLUNTEER WORK.

I could find no reliable statistics on volunteering in India, but my modestly-informed guess is that we are nowhere close to those numbers. The good news is that volunteerism as a concept is not new in our society and is deeply embedded in social structures, building a stronger sense of community and trust. We continue our social networks and support structures in our cities, but these net-